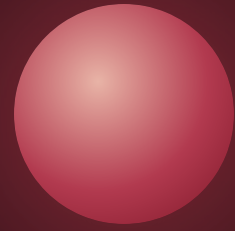


A Novel

CRIMSON EMPIRE

THE RISE OF MUQSIT

by *Sheharzad Salabuddin*



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Lahore Fort, 1566 — Lahore, present day





Prologue

THE BLOOD BENEATH LAHORE

Long before Lahore became a city of empires, kings, gardens, mosques, markets, and crowded streets, something else lived beneath its soil.

Something that did not belong to the world of men.

The oldest vampires called it **the Crimson Blood**.

They believed that the first vampires were not created by a curse or a bite. They believed they were born from an ancient bloodline whose origins had been forgotten even by the oldest creatures alive.

For centuries, the bloodline remained hidden.

Until Lahore.

In 1566, beneath the newly constructed Lahore Fort, two vampires discovered a secret chamber that had been sealed long before the Mughal Empire existed.

Inside was a stone inscription written in a language no living vampire could read.

Only one sentence remained understandable:

When the blood of two worlds becomes one, the empire will rise again.

The two vampires were Azaar and Jasmine.

They had no idea that the prophecy would eventually lead to a man named Muqsit.



Chapter One

THE BEAUTY BENEATH THE FORT

Lahore Fort, 1566

The sun had just dipped behind the red sandstone walls, leaving the sky washed in a bruised-purple glow. The fort, alive and loud by day, slowly shifted into something older, quieter, almost watchful. Torches flickered against carved pillars, and the evening breeze carried the scent of smoke, dust, and rosewater.

But beneath all that, beneath the courtyards and chambers, beneath the feet of soldiers and nobles, something ancient stirred.

A heartbeat that did not belong to any human.

THE UNDERGROUND WORLD

Far below the fortress, hidden behind a collapsed corridor that no one had walked through in decades, lived the ones forgotten by time: the vampires.

Their chamber was carved out centuries before the Mughal Empire existed, an underground web of tunnels where even torches feared to burn too brightly.

Among them was Jasmine.

She sat quietly on a smooth stone bench, her long black hair falling like silk down her back. Even in darkness, her beauty glowed softly, as if she carried her own moonlight. Her eyes, deep and liquid-dark, watched the tremble of a single torch flame from across the room.

She heard every sound in the fort above: footsteps, whispers, arguments, fear. But most of all, she heard the heartbeat of the one she loved: Azaar.

He approached her silently, though she sensed him long before he arrived. His tall figure emerged from the shadows; his expression softened the moment he saw her.

"You're quiet tonight," he murmured.

Jasmine's lips curved in a faint smile. "The humans are angry again. Their fighting shakes the walls."

Azaar frowned. "It is getting worse."

She tilted her head. "Will it trouble us?"

Azaar hesitated. "Yes."

Jasmine looked toward the ceiling, where the muffled shouts of men echoed faintly. "Then the night will be dangerous."

THE FIRE ABOVE

Above ground, Lahore Fort was erupting. A misunderstanding between Hindu and Muslim workers had turned into insults, then shoves, then blades. A cry rang out in the courtyard, followed by a clang of metal.

Guards rushed to break the fight, torches swaying wildly, shadows leaping across the walls.

In the panic, no one noticed a frightened teenage watercarrier named Armaan slipping into a lower passageway. He heard whispers. He felt cold. He sensed something unnatural.

And when he saw the faint glow of Jasmine's eyes from the darkness, he dropped his bucket and ran screaming. That scream reached the courtyard. That scream changed everything.

THE DISCOVERY

"Who's down there?" A soldier shouted.

"Search the tunnels. Someone's hiding!"

Five guards rushed toward the sealed corridor.

Azaar felt the vibrations of their footsteps instantly. His eyes widened.

"They're coming," he whispered. "Jasmine, we have to go."

But it was too late.

The chains clattered. Torches stabbed through the tunnel. Boots thundered into the chamber.

And then the soldiers saw her.

Jasmine stepped back instinctively as the torchlight illuminated her delicate features. Her beauty stunned them at first, so impossibly ethereal they thought she was a woman sculpted from moonlight. Then she hissed softly, revealing a glint of her fangs.

"She's not human!"

"Get her!"

"Catch the creature!"

The soldiers lunged.

THE CHASE

Azaar grabbed Jasmine's hand and pulled her through a side tunnel. They moved faster than any human could chase, but the fort above was in chaos; hundreds of people awake, shouting, scattering.

More soldiers poured into the lower passages. Jasmine and Azaar emerged into a courtyard, but torches were everywhere.

"There!" A voice screamed.

"Stop her!"

"Surround them!"

Jasmine looked at Azaar, her eyes full of fear he hadn't seen in centuries.

"We won't outrun them all," she whispered.

Azaar tightened his grip on her hand. "I won't let them take you."

But humans, in their terror, become brave. Dozens of them rushed forward with nets, ropes, and spears dipped in sacred oils. Jasmine fought, graceful and deadly, but a net dropped over her. She struggled, but iron chains wrapped around her arms, pulling her to her knees.

"Azaar!" She cried.

He roared, throwing men aside like dust, but they were too many. Ten, then twenty soldiers piled onto him, forcing him down. The lovers' hands reached for each other, fingertips brushing, before the soldiers tore them apart.

THE CAPTURE

The courtyard exploded with light and shouting. Both vampires were dragged in opposite directions. Jasmine tried to twist freely, but the sacred iron burned her skin. Azaar fought until the ground was stained with dust and sweat, but the humans did not stop.

Word raced through the fort: "They are demons! They cannot die!"

Messengers ran to Emperor Akbar. Hours later, the emperor arrived, calm and composed, though his eyes held curiosity. He studied Jasmine first, her strange stillness, her unnatural beauty, her silent fury. She did not look at him. She looked only at Azaar across the courtyard.

"Jahanpanah," a guard whispered, trembling, "they feel no pain. Their wounds heal. They will not die."

Akbar nodded slowly. "Then death is not our answer. If these creatures cannot die, then we must bind them, so the world never sees them again."

His voice echoed through the night: "Wrap them alive. Seal them in boxes. Bury them deep."

THE BREAKING OF TWO HEARTS

Jasmine cried out as the guards covered her in layers of silk and iron coils. Azaar roared her name until his voice broke.

"Jasmine! Jasmine!"

They forced Jasmine into a heavy wooden coffin, her hands tied to her sides. Tears glimmered in her eyes, not for the pain, but for Azaar.

"Azaar... don't forget me," she whispered desperately.

Across the courtyard, as chains tightened around him, Azaar shouted back, "I will find you! Even if it takes a thousand years!"

The lids shut. Nails hammered. Boxes were sealed. The coffins were carried into the deepest tunnels beneath Lahore Fort, where darkness swallowed them whole.

Thus began the long sleep of the undead, alive, aware, waiting.

*Chapter Two*

AWAKENING AFTER CENTURIES

Four hundred fifty-seven years later, Greater Iqbal Park, Lahore

The evening sky glowed gold as children filled the field with laughter and the thuds of a well-loved cricket ball. Families picnicked under trees, teenagers raced their bicycles along the pathways, and the ancient fort stood silently in the background, weathered by time but still watching everything.

Among the children playing cricket was a twelve-year-old boy named Faris, skinny and bright-eyed, the kind who always hit the ball too hard. Today was no different. He swung the bat with all his strength. The ball soared high in the sky, higher, and then it vanished beyond the boundary, dropping somewhere close to the old underground passages of Lahore Fort.

Faris groaned. His friends groaned louder.

"Faris! Again!"

"Go bring it! We only have one ball!"

Faris sighed and jogged toward the ancient stone steps that led beneath the fort. The evening air grew colder as he descended. The sounds of the park faded. The shadows thickened.

Faris had never gone this far into the tunnels before. He swallowed hard as he stepped deeper, calling softly for his lost ball.

Then he saw it: a long chamber coated in dust and silence. Cobwebs drifted like old curtains. The air smelled ancient.

In the center of the room stood two enormous wooden coffins. Faris froze.

"This is not my cricket ball place..." he whispered.

He took one shaky step forward. A long, thick iron coil wrapped around the seams. The coffins looked as if they belonged to a forgotten world. Faris reached out, barely touching the wood. The coffin creaked. He jumped back.

Then the lid slid open on its own.

Inside lay a man untouched by time, skin pale, features sharp and perfect. He looked as if he had just fallen asleep moments ago. Azaar.

The second coffin opened. Inside lay Jasmine, her face serene, glowing softly in the darkness as if the air itself honored her beauty.

Faris gasped loudly, stumbling back. Suddenly, a force lifted him slightly off the ground. His feet hovered an inch above the dusty floor. Panic surged as the chill of the vampires' presence wrapped around him like a shadow.

Their chests rose with the first breath they had taken in almost five centuries. Minutes passed like heartbeats. Then Jasmine's eyes slowly opened. Azaar's eyes followed. Their pupils glowed a deep crimson.

Faris screamed with everything inside him and flailed in the air, then sprinted toward the exit, dropping his bat and ball.

He burst out of the tunnel into the open field of Iqbal Park, shaking violently.

"There are bodies inside the fort!" he shouted. "They woke up! I saw them! I swear!"

People surrounded him instantly.

"What bodies?"

"What are you talking about?"

"Is this some kind of prank?"

But Faris insisted with trembling hands and watery eyes. His voice cracked as he described the coffins, the man and woman inside them, the way their eyes opened.

When they reached the room, it was empty. No coffins. No chains. No silk. Not even dust disturbed. The place looked untouched as if no one had stepped inside for centuries.

Azaar and Jasmine rose fully. Shadows stretched around them as they moved silently, gathering things from their surroundings. They set small fires, burning debris and dust before stepping into the open.

When the smoke cleared, they saw shops nearby filled with clothes. Carefully, they crept forward, hidden in the shadows, took garments, and dressed themselves, blending into this new world.

As they walked through the streets, their eyes widened in shock. Buildings, vehicles, lights, they were in a world completely unlike the one they had known.

The year was 2023.

Azaar and Jasmine stopped, staring at the modern city around them. Shock, wonder, and a quiet thrill filled their hearts. The future was theirs to explore.

*Chapter Three*

BLOOD AND POWER

The city never slept. But tonight, it shivered.

Azaar stood on the rooftop of his skyscraper, the neon lights of Lahore glinting below. Jasmine was beside him, her eyes scanning the streets with the precision of a predator. The two centuries-old vampires had built an empire, but power always invited challengers.

From the shadows, new threats emerged. Rival gangs had grown bold, unaware of who truly ruled the night. Whispers of unnatural strength, impossible speed, and eyes that burned crimson began to circulate.

A single gunshot echoed from the alley below.

Azaar moved faster than thought, leaping down silently. Jasmine followed, her movements liquid and silent. In seconds, they were surrounded—half a dozen gang members, armed and confident.

"You don't belong here," one of them sneered. "This is our city now."

Azaar tilted his head, his voice calm but deadly. "You only belong where I allow you."

Chaos erupted. The vampires moved like shadows and storms. Bullets struck walls, ricocheted, or were shattered mid-air by their unnatural reflexes. Azaar disarmed two men with a flick of his wrist. Jasmine's hand moved faster than the eye could follow, knives appearing from nowhere, leaving streaks of silver in the dim light.

Within moments, the gang lay unconscious, terrified, unable to comprehend what had just happened. Azaar leaned close to the leader, whispering: "Tell everyone. Or next time... you won't wake up."

THE MAFIA'S CHALLENGE

Word spread quickly through the criminal underworld. The "ghosts of Lahore" were real. Fear was not enough. Some saw opportunity; alliances, betrayals, and power struggles began to form. Azaar and Jasmine knew they needed more than brute strength. Strategy became their weapon. They infiltrated rival gangs, sowing distrust, and turning allies against each other, all while keeping their true identities secret.

Luxury parties masked deadly deals. Streets filled with laughter hid silent killings. No one dared to challenge them openly, yet whispers of rebellion grew louder.

THE HUNT BEGINS

One night, a mysterious figure appeared, another vampire, younger but stronger, with hunger and cunning that rivaled Azaar's own. He had come from the north, seeking to claim Lahore as his own.

The streets became a chessboard. Every move counted. Every shadow was a threat. Azaar and Jasmine were no longer just rulers; they were hunters in a city teetering on the edge of blood and chaos.

The city watched unaware as two immortal forces prepared for war, one that would shake Lahore to its very foundations.

*Chapter Four*

A NEW LOVER

The city was quiet tonight, but Jasmine's mind was anything but. She sat in her penthouse apartment, the glow of multiple laptop screens reflecting off her pale face. The hum of servers and notifications filled the air, a digital symphony of information and opportunity.

Azaar had changed over centuries. The man she had loved was gone. In his place was someone colder, sharper, even abusive. Power had twisted him; cruelty had become his language.

Jasmine's fingers danced over the keyboard. Social media profiles, security cameras, digital archives, every piece of information was a potential lead. She searched for humans whose blood called to her, whose presence could feed her power, whose lives could become her prey or her salvation.

Among the endless digital faces, she froze. There he was. Someone human yet carrying a presence that resonated in her soul. A stranger whose picture and eyes drew her in like a whisper from centuries past.

She opened his profile:

SUBJECT LOCATED

Name

Muqsit

Location

Cavalry Ground

Siblings	deceased
Family	deceased

She felt a deep, instinctual interest in finding him. Her heart betrayed her. This hunt was different. This was not blood; it was connection, desire, and hope.

Alerts pinged. Encrypted messages intercepted from unknown sources. Vampires. Real vampires. And they were coming to kill him.

Jasmine grabbed her leather jacket and custom pistols. Her boots hit the pavement as she raced through alleys and over rooftops, shadows melting behind her. Muqsit was completely oblivious, walking home unaware of the deadly predators closing in.

She spotted them first. Three vampires, lithe and pale, eyes glowing with hunger. They moved like smoke, silent and deadly.

"Not tonight," Jasmine muttered. Two quick shots, one vampire crumpled. She rolled sideways, narrowly avoiding another attack, firing again. The third vampire advanced, faster than humanly possible. Jasmine anticipated every move. In one fluid motion, she kicked him into a wall, plunging a dagger into his chest. He hissed, then collapsed into smoke and swirling ashes.

Muqsit stared, pale and shaking. "Wh-what... how?"

Jasmine turned, crimson eyes reflecting streetlights, expression fierce yet calm. "Not now. You will understand later. Just stay quiet and move."

*Chapter Five*

MUQSIT STEPS INTO HER VAMPIRE EMPIRE

It was her private empire in Gulberg. She could not explain why she felt this pull toward him. Muqsit was confused, uncertain why she had brought him into this world.

She showed him she was a vampire. Muqsit fell back, shocked. "What the hell are you?" He stammered, trying to escape.

Jasmine pressed the buttons to lock the doors, preventing him from leaving. "You are here," she said, eyes glowing crimson. "And this world... my world... will change you, whether you wish it or not."

Muqsit's heart raced. He realized he had crossed a line from which there was no return. The empire around him was centuries in the making, full of danger, power, and secrets.

*Chapter Six*

THE INITIATION OF MUQSIT

The city of Lahore slept under a pale moon.

Inside her empire, Jasmine led Muqsit through vaults of technology, centuries-old artifacts, and secret passageways. She explained her empire's rules, the streets under her control, and the art of surviving in a world of humans and vampires.

In a moonlit hall, she gestured three figures emerging from the shadows. Vampires.

"Your first test," she said softly. "You survive... or you perish."

The attackers lunged. Muqsit froze. Jasmine moved like liquid, taking them down with deadly precision. He realized he could not outrun this world, but he could learn or die trying.

"You are here now," Jasmine whispered, crimson eyes glowing. "And this world... my world... will change you, whether you wish it or not."

Fear, awe, and a strange thrill coursed through his veins. He had stepped into a world century in the making, where love, loyalty, power, and blood collided.

Outside, Lahore's skyline glimmered. Jasmine and her new protégé, Muqsit, stood together in the shadows of Gulberg, a human stepping into a vampire empire stretching centuries into the night.

*Chapter Seven*

THE RETURN OF THE FORGOTTEN VAMPIRE

Jasmine stood at the edge of the Walled City, her eyes scanning the ancient alleys and crumbling walls. The air was thick with the ghosts of history, carrying whispers of the lives lost centuries ago. Beside her, Muqsit followed silently; curiosity and fear etched into his features.

"I want to show you something," Jasmine said softly. "Something you need to understand about who I am... about who we are."

They moved through narrow lanes, the city alive with the hum of vendors and footsteps, yet beneath it all, a memory lingered. Jasmine's voice broke the silence.

"Long ago, in the time of Emperor Akbar, humans feared us. They could not understand us, could not tolerate our existence. Soldiers came, armed with iron, chains, and ignorance. They did not see our hearts. They only saw what they feared. And in their fear, they killed... everyone we loved."

"All," Jasmine whispered, her crimson eyes glinting with sorrow, "only Azaar and I and some survived."

Muqsit listened, horrified. The weight of centuries pressed in the air around them.

"The sun is coming," Jasmine said urgently. "We must go. Azaar is coming... he will kill you if he finds you here."

Muqsit's pulse quickened. Fear and adrenaline surged through him as he realized the danger of even standing in these historic streets.

Jasmine placed a hand on his shoulder. "I brought you here because you need to know the truth. You need to see the world as it was, so you can understand what we fight for, what we protect."

Together, they moved swiftly through the Walled City, shadows stretching long across the streets. Jasmine's voice was a quiet echo against the walls.

"Those we lost... I will honor them. And now, Muqsit, you are part of this story. Part of this fight. Part of our family."

The city, ancient and alive, seemed to hold its breath. For the first time in centuries, Jasmine allowed herself a moment of vulnerability, sharing her grief, her love, and her purpose.

Muqsit, standing beside her, realized that the vampire empire he had entered was more than power and blood. It was memory, vengeance, love, and unbreakable bonds spanning centuries.

And in that moment, he knew he would follow her through every shadowed alley, every danger, every secret of the night.

*Chapter Eight*

THE BATTLE FOR MUQSIT BEGINS

The moon hung low over Gulberg, casting pale light across Jasmine's private empire. Inside, the hum of machines and the faint scent of incense filled the air, but the tension was thick. Jasmine and Muqsit faced each other across the training hall, shadows stretching along the walls.

"You must be ready," Jasmine said, her crimson eyes blazing. "Azaar knows about you. He's coming. If you aren't prepared... he will kill you."

Muqsit swallowed, fear and determination warring inside him. "I won't let him... not if you train me."

Jasmine nodded. "Good. Then focus. Every movement, every strike, every breath counts. In my world, hesitation is death."

They began.

The hall echoed with the clash of blades and the swish of bodies moving faster than human eyes could follow. Jasmine struck first, her attacks precise, elegant, and deadly. Muqsit blocked and dodged, his muscles straining as he tried to anticipate her moves.

"Faster!" Jasmine hissed. "You must feel, not think! Your instincts must control you!"

Hours passed. Sweat, blood, and shadows mingled as Muqsit pushed beyond his limits. Jasmine taught him the art of vampire combat: speed, agility, and the terrifying precision that centuries of experience had honed.

But this was more than physical training. Jasmine whispered lessons about strategy, reading opponents, understanding fear, and turning it into power. She forced Muqsit to confront his own instincts, to embrace his inner strength.

By the end of the night, Muqsit was exhausted, but he had changed. His eyes burned with understanding, his body moved with a newfound grace, and his resolve hardened.

"You've learned much tonight," Jasmine said, her voice low but approving. "But the real test will come when he arrives. When Azaar comes for you... will you survive, or will you die?"

Muqsit looked up at her, determination in his gaze. "I'll survive. I'll fight. I won't let him take me."

Jasmine allowed herself the faintest smile. "Good. Then tomorrow, the battle begins."

Outside, the streets of Lahore remained quiet, but shadows stretched long, whispering of a storm about to descend. The fight for Muqsit's life, and the soul of the vampire empire was only just beginning.

*Chapter Nine*

AZAAR'S HUNT

The moon hung low over Gulberg, casting long shadows across Jasmine's empire. Every corner of the ancient yet modern fortress seemed alive, whispering secrets of centuries past.

Inside, Jasmine paced silently, crimson eyes scanning the city below from her penthouse. Muqsit was hidden in a secure chamber, unaware of the danger closing in. Jasmine's mind raced, Azaar was coming, and he would not stop until he found him.

A low rumble echoed from the streets below. Azaar had arrived, and he was not alone. Behind him, a team of vampires moved like shadows, lean, deadly, eyes glowing crimson, fangs glinting in the moonlight. Each carried centuries of experience, strength, and loyalty to Azaar alone.

"Jasmine!" Azaar bellowed, his voice echoing through the halls. "I know you are protecting him! Give him to me!"

Jasmine's crimson eyes met his, unwavering. "Azaar, you don't understand. He is not yours to take. Not yet. Not now."

Azaar's patience snapped. Every century of dominance, every suppressed rage, erupted. His team spread through the empire, silent and precise, surrounding corridors and entrances.

"You dare defy me?!" he roared. "I made this city mine! And now you protect a human?"

Jasmine's hand rested lightly on her pistols, her dagger glinting under dim light. "He is part of this empire now. And I will not let you touch him."

Azaar gestured, and his vampires fanned out. They moved faster than the eye could follow, surrounding corridors, entrances, and stairwells. Each one was a weapon, trained to kill with precision.

Jasmine activated the empire's defenses, doors sealed, hidden barriers rose, and traps set centuries ago hummed to life. Shadows twisted, walls shifted, and the ancient fortress seemed to come alive, ready to protect its mistress and her new protégé.

Then, unexpectedly, Muqsit emerged. His eyes sharp, posture confident. He moved swiftly through the room, gathering weapons from hidden caches: blades, pistols, and even improvised tools from the empire's vaults.

Jasmine's eyes widened. "Muqsit! What are you doing?"

Muqsit met her gaze. "Calm down. Let me handle this."

Azaar laughed, a deep, echoing sound that ignored Jasmine's protests. With a swipe of his hand, tables, computers, and even chemicals scattered across the floor, turning the room into a chaotic battlefield.

The clash began. Muqsit moved with surprising skill, disarming, dodging, and countering attacks with precision. Every strike he made was calculated, every move fluid, showing training far beyond what Azaar expected from a human.

At one point, Muqsit lunged with a blade aimed straight for Azaar's heart. The vampire lord staggered, an unfamiliar feeling of vulnerability flashing in his crimson eyes.

"This human..." Azaar thought, unease creeping in. He realized Muqsit was not to be underestimated.

Feeling unsafe, Azaar called out, "Team! Now!" His loyal vampires swooped in, and Muqsit was forced to retreat. Azaar called off the immediate attack, signaling his team to regroup. Slowly, they exited the empire, leaving a tense silence behind, the aftermath of battle and destruction scattered across the room.

Jasmine exhaled, tense but relieved. Muqsit looked at her, eyes blazing. "I told you... let me handle it."

She nodded, pride and worried mingling in her expression. "You are ready... but Azaar won't forget this."

The empire trembled under the echoes of the confrontation, and both knew the war for control and survival was far from over.

*Chapter Ten*

THE COUSIN'S VENGEANCE

The night air in Gulberg was thick with tension, shadows stretching long across Jasmine's empire. Inside, a storm was brewing, a storm born of centuries-old rivalries, love, and blood.

Azaar had made a choice. In a desperate moment before, when both his and Jasmine's lives teetered on the edge of death, he had drained his cousin's blood, leaving him to die. The act had been violent, fueled by fear, power, and the instinct to protect what he held dear.

But the strike against his cousin had not broken Azaar, it had awakened something in him. After being stabbed, facing mortality for perhaps the first time in centuries, Azaar's mind shifted. He realized that to defeat Muqsit, he needed his cousin's unmatched power.

The ritual began. Ancient incantations, centuries-old spells, and the vampire blood that had once pulsed through a living, deadly body all merged into a fragile symphony of life and death. Azaar cut his own skin, letting his crimson blood flow freely to feed his cousin, a gift of life and power mingled in one act. The chamber glowed crimson as the blood met the still form, searing with energy and awakening what had long been dormant.

The cousin's body stirred, muscles twitching with the return of life, eyes opening to reveal a depth of power that even Azaar had feared. He was no longer just a vampire, he was a force of nature, the strongest of their kind, and his loyalty would be tested.

Azaar rose, his eyes meeting his cousin's. A silent understanding passed between them: the blood had returned life, but it also returned the hunger for control, revenge, and domination.

Outside, the city remained unaware, lights flickering gently, innocent humans oblivious to the brewing war within Jasmine's empire. Inside, Muqsit sensed the shift immediately, power unlike anything he had faced before now filled the air. His training, his courage, and his bond with Jasmine would all be tested, for now Azaar and his cousin were united, and their target was clear.

Jasmine's crimson eyes narrowed as she watched the reunion. Her heart wavered between fear and resolve. The battle lines had been drawn, and soon, the war for Gulberg, for Muqsit, and for the very balance of power among vampires would erupt.

The stage was set. The predator and the protégé. The ancient and the new. And in the heart of Lahore, centuries of history were about to collide with the present in a storm of blood, fury, and vengeance.

*Chapter Eleven*

CHAOS IN THE SHADOWS

Jasmine's crimson eyes scanned every screen in her empire. Every alley, every street, every possible route, she needed answers. The CCTV feeds blinked with motion until she finally saw them: the unknown kidnappers, dragging Muqsit into an abandoned warehouse near the outskirts of Lahore. Among them, a strange figure moved with methodical precision, the scientist.

Without hesitation, she revved her Suzuki, the engine roaring like a predator announcing its hunt. The city blurred past her as she tore through the streets, instincts honed over centuries guiding every turn.

She arrived just as the kidnappers were about to disappear into the building. In a flash, she struck. Her pistols fired, shadows dancing across the walls, striking the intruders before they could react. Muqsit swayed, dizzy from the drugs the scientist had injected him with.

"Muqsit!" Jasmine shouted, rushing to shield him.

The scientist stepped forward, calm and sinister. "Ah, Jasmine... I see you found us. Your protégé will soon become stronger than Azaar himself," he said, smirking. "The drug will unlock his true potential."

The air suddenly shifted. From the darkness, Azaar and his team emerged, fangs bared, eyes glowing crimson, weapons in hand. Their presence turned the battlefield into a war zone in an instant.

The kidnappers tried to hide, but Jasmine's fury was unrelenting. Bullets, silver blades, and dark energy clashed in a violent storm of chaos. Azaar's team fired, retaliating with precision honed over centuries, while Muqsit, though dazed and drugged, instinctively grabbed a weapon to defend himself.

Time seemed to slow. Jasmine's eyes fell on Muqsit. A crimson-tinted bullet struck him. His body crumpled to the ground, and a strangled cry escaped his lips.

"No!" Jasmine screamed. Her voice split the night, raw and primal.

Her teeth elongated, fangs gleaming in the dim light. She moved like a storm, impossible to follow, tearing through Azaar's team and the kidnappers with lethal precision. Shadows twisted, walls shattered, and every strike was a hurricane of vengeance.

The scientist stumbled, bleeding from a shot. He lifted a trembling hand, holding the syringe toward Jasmine. "Jasmine... bite him," he gasped, nodding at Muqsit. "Make him... the most powerful... half-vampire, half-human... the sun will not kill him..."

Jasmine's crimson eyes narrowed, fury and confusion battling within her. The scientist continued, weakly extending the syringe. "For you... use this... to survive the sun... and you will be safe... during the day..."

Jasmine's hand hovered over the syringe, instincts screaming, fangs still bared, as the night's chaos swirled around them. A choice had to be made, and the path forward would change everything.

*Chapter Twelve*

THE AWAKENING OF MUQSIT

The warehouse trembled under the echoes of gunfire and supernatural fury. Smoke mingled with the cold night air as Jasmine stood over Muqsit's trembling form. The syringe in the scientist's hand gleamed under the dim lights, a strange promise of power and survival.

Her crimson eyes locked onto Muqsit. His skin was pale, sweat beading on his forehead, and his chest heaved from the drugs coursing through his veins. He looked at her with trust and fear, his voice barely a whisper.

"Jasmine... what's happening to me?"

Before she could answer, the scientist wheezed, blood dripping from a wound in his shoulder. "Do it... he must become... the hybrid... only then... can he face Azaar..."

Jasmine's hand hovered over the syringe. Her fangs glinted in the pale light, her instincts screaming that this was the moment that could save or destroy everything.

She leaned close to Muqsit. "You trust me?"

He nodded weakly, his eyes still dazed from the drugs but filled with unwavering faith. "I trust you. Do what you must."

With a decisive motion, Jasmine injected the serum into Muqsit's neck. The effect was immediate. His body convulsed, muscles rippling, veins glowing faint crimson beneath

his skin. Pain twisted his face, but his eyes, once human brown, flared bright red. His heart pounded, not with fear, but with a newfound, fierce strength.

The scientist gasped, blood bubbling at his lips, and then collapsed. "Go... go..." he whispered, dying, eyes dimming.

Jasmine knelt beside him, pressing her fangs to his neck, drinking the last of his blood. She then took the syringe and injected the serum into her own neck. A surge of power coursed through her veins, making her even faster, stronger, and immune to the sun. Her crimson eyes glowed brighter than ever.

Muqsit rose unsteadily, looking at his hands, then at Jasmine. "I... I can feel it... power... speed... everything..."

Jasmine's hand rested on his shoulder. "Now we are both ready. Together, we can stop Azaar and survive."

Outside, Azaar and his team regrouped, unaware that the tide of this battle had shifted. Muqsit's transformation glimmered with potential unlike any vampire the city had seen in centuries, and Jasmine's enhanced power made her unstoppable during the day.

The night was no longer just shadows and danger, it was a proving ground. A new chapter of the war between humans, vampires, and hybrids had begun.

And in the streets of Lahore, under the watchful moon, a half-human, half-vampire warrior and his immortal partner prepared to face the vampire lord who had once terrorized centuries, with everything at stake.

*Chapter Thirteen*

CLASH OF TITANS

Moonlight bathed the towering spires of Azaar's empire. Jasmine and Muqsit stood at the gates, their shadows stretching across the stone floor. Every heartbeat thrummed with anticipation.

Azaar's laughter echoed from the balcony above. "Well, well... look who finally decided to visit," he sneered, crimson eyes glinting with amusement.

Jasmine's gaze sharpened, frozen in disbelief. Her voice trembled slightly as she whispered to Muqsit, "His cousin... he's alive... and stronger than anything we've faced. We can't defeat him."

Muqsit's lips curved into a slow, confident smile. "Let's see," he said softly, the thrill of battle lighting his eyes.

Without another word, Muqsit stepped forward. Across the battlefield, Azaar's cousin emerged, a towering figure with power radiating from every movement. The air seemed to thrum around him, crackling with energy, every muscle coiled and ready.

The fight began. Muqsit lunged, striking with precision, his half-human, half-vampire strength evident in every blow. The cousin countered with devastating force, each strike shaking the ground, sending shards of stone and debris flying. They collided like two storms, blows echoing like thunder, sparks of energy flashing with every impact.

Jasmine and Azaar watched from above, their eyes locked on the battlefield. Jasmine's worry deepened, but Muqsit's fearless determination stirred hope within her. Azaar's

expression, though masked with arrogance, betrayed a flicker of unease, this human-hybrid was no ordinary opponent.

The clash intensified. Muqsit ducked under a sweeping blow, rolling to regain balance, then delivered a series of strikes that tested even the cousin's legendary reflexes. Rocks shattered, pillars cracked, and the empire itself seemed to tremble under their fury.

Jasmine's crimson eyes glowed brighter, her hands gripping the railing tightly as she whispered, "You can do this... Muqsit... I believe in you."

Muqsit met her gaze briefly, nodding, before focusing again on the towering vampire before him. Power, speed, and centuries of training collided in a chaotic, yet mesmerizing dance of strength.

The battle had begun, and there was no turning back. The fate of Lahore, their empire, and their very lives rested on the outcome of this clash between Muqsit and Azaar's most formidable vampire, his cousin.

*Chapter Fourteen*

THE RISE OF MUQSIT

The battlefield was in ruins. Pillars lay shattered, dust swirled in the pale moonlight, and the air was thick with the scent of blood and iron. Muqsit and Azaar's cousin faced each other, every movement a clash of unstoppable force against indomitable power.

The cousin staggered slightly, a rare sign of weakness. His eyes, once blazing with confidence, flickered with uncertainty. "Azaar..." he gasped, voice strained, "we... we cannot defeat him..."

Azaar's crimson eyes narrowed, a mixture of disbelief and fury flashing across his face. Jasmine clenched her fists, her fear tempered with awe. She had never seen Muqsit move like this half-human, half-vampire, every strike precise, every reflex instantaneous, every blow imbued with power beyond imagination.

Muqsit's eyes glowed with determination. Every moment of training, every secret Jasmine had shared, every drop of vampire and human blood within him, surged together into pure strength. He dodged, countered, and struck with a precision that left the cousin unbalanced, teetering on the edge of defeat.

"Your reign ends here," Muqsit whispered, voice calm yet filled with unstoppable authority.

The cousin lunged one final time, but Muqsit sidestepped effortlessly, and in a single, fluid motion, delivered a strike that severed his head. Time seemed to freeze as it fell to the ground, eyes wide with disbelief and fear.

Azaar stepped back, his jaw tight, watching the cousin's lifeless body with a mix of anger and awe. Jasmine's hand flew to her mouth, crimson eyes wide in shock, yet a spark of relief and pride shone through her fear.

Muqsit stood tall, chest heaving, glowing faintly under the moonlight. The battlefield was silent now, save for the distant echo of destruction. He had proven himself, the most powerful hybrid the world had ever seen.

"This... this changes everything," Azaar muttered, his voice low, almost a growl. "We underestimated him."

Jasmine stepped closer to Muqsit, placing a hand on his shoulder. "You did it... you're ready for everything the world throws at you."

Muqsit's gaze met hers, unwavering. "This is only the beginning," he said, crimson eyes blazing with promise and warning. "And anyone who threatens us... will fall."

The ruins of the empire bore witness to the rise of a new power, one that would shape the destiny of Lahore, and the vampire world, for centuries to come.

*Chapter Seventeen*

AZAAR'S REVENGE

The echo of his cousin's death still reverberated in Azaar's mind. Rage burned hotter than ever, his centuries-old pride wounded. He paced in his private chamber within the remnants of his empire, crimson eyes flashing with fury. Jasmine and Muqsit had outmaneuvered him, but he was far from finished.

"This isn't over," Azaar whispered through gritted teeth. "Not by a long shot."

Outside, the city of Lahore slept uneasily, unaware that the shadows held a storm yet to come. Every alley, every rooftop, every darkened street corner could become a battlefield once Azaar unleashed his wrath.

Azaar's thoughts shifted. Strategy demanded more than brute force. With a sudden resolve, he decided to leave Lahore. He would travel to Islamabad, seeking counsel from the oldest vampires, the guardians of wisdom and power, who had long resided far from the city, safe from the chaos surrounding Lahore Fort.

These ancient vampires already knew the danger brewing among younger bloods. Some had lived hidden in the Himalayan mountains after Azaar and Jasmine had buried their own secrets, keeping themselves shielded from centuries of conflict.

"This isn't just about revenge," Azaar murmured, voice cold but calculated. "It's about reclaiming what is rightfully mine... and crushing anyone who dares defy me."

Meanwhile, Jasmine and Muqsit returned to the ruins of the battlefield. Muqsit's expression was unreadable, his eyes glowing faintly from the surge of power coursing

through him. Jasmine's hand found his, a silent gesture of solidarity.

"You can feel it, can't you?" she asked softly. "He's plotting. Azaar will come for you."

Muqsit nodded, his jaw firm. "Let him come. I'm ready now. Every step he takes... every move he makes, I will be ready. And this time, no one will stand in my way."

Jasmine's eyes softened. "And I'll be by your side. Always."

From the distance, in the safety of Islamabad's shadows, the oldest vampires watched, sensing the brewing storm in Lahore. Even from afar, the tension was palpable. Every heartbeat, every flicker of light in the streets below, reminded them of the fragile balance, and the power struggles that were about to erupt.

The war was far from over. The game of shadows, blood, and power was entering a new phase. And in this game, only one truth remained: in Lahore, the night belonged to the strongest.

*Chapter Eighteen*

THE GATHERING OF SHADOWS

Azaar moved through the winding paths of Islamabad, the cold Himalayan winds biting at his cloak. In the distance, the ancient vampires' stronghold loomed, carved into the mountains like a fortress of eternity. Their eyes, centuries-old and sharp, watched him approach, measuring his resolve, reading the storm in his heart.

"My old allies," Azaar spoke, his voice echoing across the stone hall. "Lahore has become a playground for the inexperienced. Jasmine, that treacherous vampire, and the boy... Muqsit... they defy everything we built. They challenge our bloodline, our power. It is time to remind them what it means to fear us."

The oldest vampires nodded, their expressions unreadable. They had witnessed empires rise and fall, lovers betray, and mortals stumble into darkness. Yet, the boldness of this new generation intrigued them. Some whispered warnings, others nodded silently, ready to follow Azaar into war.

Back in Lahore, Jasmine and Muqsit were unaware of the alliance forming against them. In the shattered remnants of the empire, Muqsit trained tirelessly, mastering his new abilities, feeling the strange balance of half-human, half-vampire strength coursing through him. Jasmine watched, protective yet impressed, knowing that the coming storm would test them beyond anything they had faced.

High above the mountains, Azaar's council convened. Ancient rituals were performed, blessings chanted, and the old magic awakened. Each vampire pledged loyalty, their fangs glinting under the pale moonlight, the air thick with the promise of bloodshed.

"We move at nightfall," Azaar declared, crimson eyes glowing like twin fires. "Lahore will remember the name Azaar. Jasmine and the boy will learn the cost of defiance."

In the shadows of Gulberg, Jasmine felt a shift in the air, an unease she could not ignore. Her eyes scanned the horizon, sensing danger beyond the city limits. Muqsit's hand found hers, a silent understanding passing between them.

"They are coming," he said quietly, his voice steady despite the tension. "But we are ready. Together."

Jasmine nodded, teeth faintly glinting under the light. "Then let them come. We will show them what this city, and this empire, truly means."

And as the sun dipped behind the mountains, Lahore braced itself for a battle that would shake the foundations of vampire power and alter the course of bloodlines for centuries to come.

*Chapter Eighteen*

THE HIMALAYAN CONCLAVE

The wind howled through the snow-capped peaks, carrying whispers of centuries-old secrets. Azaar stepped onto the jagged cliffs of the Himalayas, his cloak flaring behind him. The air was thin, cold enough to bite skin, but it invigorated his senses. Crimson eyes scanned the horizon: the fortress of the Elder Vampires loomed, carved directly into the mountain's heart.

The ancient ones watched silently as he approached. Their eyes, glowing faint amber, reflected the firelight of torches scattered along the fortress walls. Each elder exuded power so ancient, so overwhelming, that even Azaar felt a shiver of reverence.

"I have come," Azaar declared, his voice echoing across the frozen courtyard. "Lahore has fallen. A hybrid—half human, half vampire—has risen. He threatens the balance. He must be stopped."

An elder stepped forward, his long silver hair flowing like liquid moonlight. "Azaar, your pride blinds you. Power without wisdom is a blade that cuts your own hand. This hybrid... Muqsit... he is unlike any we have seen. The blood is pure, untainted by centuries of darkness."

Azaar's jaw tightened. "I do not care about purity. He has humiliated me. He has killed my cousin. I will reclaim what is mine, and no council will stop me."

The elder's eyes softened, but his voice carried authority. "There are ways, Azaar, ways to surpass even him, but the cost is great. You must embrace both shadow and light, sacrifice what you love, and confront the humanity that still lingers in your veins."

Azaar's crimson gaze flickered. Inside him, the storm of rage battled with the hint of caution. "Tell me what I must do," he said, voice low and dangerous.

The council murmured among themselves, a symphony of ancient knowledge. Finally, the elder spoke: "A ritual exists, one that binds your strength to the highest peak of the Himalayas, combining centuries of vampire power with elemental forces of the mountains. You will become a force that not even the hybrid can face... but you will be changed forever. Your heart may not survive intact."

Azaar's hands clenched. His mind raced with visions of Muqsit and Jasmine, of the empire he had lost. And yet... the lure of ultimate power called to him, a siren song of vengeance.

"I accept," he whispered. "Show me the path. Let the hybrid feel the weight of my wrath."

*Chapter 19*

THE ALLIANCE OF THE OLD ONES

A zaar flew over the mountains, the cold Himalayan winds cutting through the night. The city of Lahore was far behind him, but his mind was fixed on one thing: Muqsit. After the recent battles, he knew the young human-turned-vampire had grown stronger far stronger than anticipated.

The oldest vampires had long lived hidden in the remote peaks of the Himalayas, away from human eyes and the chaos of Lahore. Their wisdom and power were unmatched, and only their guidance could tip the scales in his favor.

When Azaar arrived, the elders were waiting. Their pale faces glowed faintly in the moonlight, eyes reflecting centuries of experience and knowledge.

"You come for aid... yet your intentions are clear," said the eldest vampire, voice like gravel.

"Yes," Azaar replied, his crimson eyes burning with resolve. "Muqsit has grown too powerful. He threatens my empire, my rule, and my life. I ask for your allegiance. Join me, lend your strength, and together we will defeat him."

The council of elders murmured among themselves. One stepped forward, a vampire older than any record, eyes like molten silver.

"Your ambition is clear, Azaar," he said slowly. "But know this: the boy is not just human, nor merely a vampire. Half-bloods hold the potential to surpass even the greatest of us."

To fight him... you will need more than strength. Strategy, precision, and understanding of his power will be required."

Azaar's jaw tightened. "I understand. I am ready to pay any price. Train us, guide us, and join my army. Together, Muqsit will fall."

The elders shared a long, silent glance. Then, in unison, they said:

"Very well. But remember... power without caution destroys everything. Train wisely, Azaar. The responsibility of this war is heavier than any blade."

Thus, the alliance was forged. Azaar's army would now include centuries-old vampires whose strength, wisdom, and deadly experience could rival even the most formidable of enemies. In the icy peaks of the Himalayas, plans were drawn, strategies honed, and a new war against Muqsit silently began one that would shake Lahore to its foundations.



SHADOWS OVER LAHORE

The city of Lahore slept under an uneasy calm. Neon lights glittered across the streets, masking the scars of previous battles. Yet, Jasmine could feel it something massive was approaching, something far beyond any enemy they had faced before.

In the penthouse of their empire, she paced, crimson eyes scanning the horizon. Every shadow seemed to whisper warnings. Her instincts, honed over centuries, screamed danger.

"Muqsit," she said urgently, finding him in the training room. "Something... something big is coming. I can feel it. We need to be ready."

Muqsit paused, sensing the tension in her voice. "What is it? Another vampire? Or something else?"

Jasmine shook her head. "I don't know yet. But it's not human. It's powerful... and it's coming for us."

Outside, the city remained oblivious. Humans wandered through streets that had already been battlefields, unaware that the night held dangers they could never comprehend. Above them, shadows shifted, moving closer with silent intent.

Muqsit clenched his fists, determination lighting his eyes. "Then we prepare. Whatever it is... we will face it together."

Jasmine nodded, a mix of fear and resolve in her gaze. She could see the future in fragments, visions of battles, blood, and power clashes but one thing was clear: the coming storm would test everything they had built, their love, their loyalty, and their empire.

The city pulsed beneath them. Somewhere in the darkness, forces gathered, waiting for the right moment to strike. And Jasmine and Muqsit, standing side by side, were ready to meet them.

*Chapter 21*

THE GRANDFATHER'S CHALLENGE

The horizon darkened as Azaar descended with his army, their shadows stretching across the streets like an approaching storm. The sound of wings and the echo of boots sent a chill through the air.

Azaar's laughter cut through the silence. "Look who is here," he called, his voice dripping with mockery and authority.

Jasmine froze. Crimson eyes widened in disbelief. "It... it can't be," she whispered.

From the midst of the army, a tall, imposing figure emerged—her grandfather. Alive. And commanding the very forces that now threatened them. His eyes, cold and unwavering, locked on Muqsit. "Kill him," he commanded, voice like iron.

Jasmine fell to her knees, desperation in her voice. "Muqsit... please! Don't do it! We cannot..."

But Muqsit's gaze was steady, unflinching. "I have to," he said quietly. He stepped forward, resolve burning like fire in his veins.

The grandfather waved his hand, and Azaar's army surged forward. Blades, fangs, and weapons collided as Muqsit faced them head-on. One by one, he dismantled their forces with precise, unstoppable power, leaving nothing but silence and destruction in his wake.

Jasmine watched, heart pounding, as the streets ran with shadows of battle. When the dust settled, all that remained were Muqsit, the grandfather, Azaar, and Jasmine.

The grandfather stepped forward, his eyes narrowing as he sized up Muqsit. "So... this is the child I underestimated," he said, disbelief in his voice. Every strike, every movement, every command Muqsit had executed had proven his power beyond measure.

Dizziness overcame the grandfather as he tried to resist. Muqsit moved with inhuman speed, and in a single decisive strike, he ended the life of the ancient vampire.

Azaar, stunned and desperate, attempted to flee. Jasmine lunged, seizing him, but he struggled with all his remaining strength. Muqsit's eyes glowed crimson, unwavering. In moments, Azaar fell, defeated, slain by the power he had once sought to control.

Jasmine's knees weakened as she watched the aftermath. The streets were silent, the night heavy with the scent of blood and victory. Muqsit stood tall, his power unmatched, the empire's future resting in his hands.

For the first time, both fear and awe reflected in Jasmine's eyes. The boy she had once protected had become something far greater than she could have imagined.

The war for Lahore had entered a new era. And Muqsit had become the strongest of them all.

*Chapter 22*

THE DAWN OF THE NEW EMPIRE

The first light of dawn crept over Lahore, painting the city in muted gold and rose hues. The battles of the night had left scars, streets littered with debris, buildings battered, shadows heavy with the memory of conflict. Yet amid the ruin, a new power emerged.

Jasmine stood beside Muqsit on the rooftop of the empire. His crimson eyes caught the morning light, reflecting centuries of strength, wisdom, and now, dominance. No enemy remained. Azaar and his loyalists, the grandfather, the rogue vampires, all defeated. The city's chaos had been cleansed by the hand of the new ruler.

Muqsit looked down at the streets of Lahore, once a battleground, now trembling under the shadow of his power. "It's quiet," he murmured. His voice was calm, yet carried the weight of authority. "For now."

Jasmine placed a hand on his arm, crimson eyes softening. "You've done what no one thought possible. But power... power changes everything. You must be careful, Muqsit. There will always be others who seek it."

He nodded, understanding the unspoken truth. Empires are never truly safe. But for this moment, peace could exist. For this moment, the city belonged to them.

Together, they descended into the heart of the empire. Vampires and humans alike, those who had survived the war, now looked to them with a mix of awe and fear. Muqsit's rise had been swift, his power undeniable. Stories of the half-human, half-vampire warrior

spread through Lahore faster than wildfire, whispered in every alley, every rooftop, every market.

In the quiet of the night, before the full bustle of human life resumed, Jasmine and Muqsit stood alone in the penthouse. The city stretched below, a kingdom reshaped by blood, loyalty, and survival.

"You're ready," Jasmine whispered, a hint of pride in her voice. "Not just to rule... but to protect."

Muqsit smiled faintly, the weight of centuries of expectation settling on his shoulders. "We'll protect it together," he said.

As the sun rose higher, its rays spilling across the skyline, Muqsit felt something unprecedented. He could walk in daylight, the scientist's syringe coursing its protection through his veins. He was no longer just a human. No longer just a vampire. He was the bridge between worlds, the apex of power, the dawn of a new empire.

And far above Lahore, in the skies, the city seemed to hum with recognition, whispering the name of its new guardian: Muqsit, the Immortal.

The war had ended. But the empire... had only just begun.

*Chapter 23*

THE OLD BLOOD STIRS

Three weeks later, Lahore

Three weeks after Azaar fell, Lahore had not gone quiet. It had gone watchful.

Muqsit felt it before Jasmine put words to it, a stillness in the city that wasn't peace, more like a held breath, waiting to see if the throne he had never asked for would hold, or crack.

"Two turf lines near Anarkali stopped settling themselves," Jasmine said, laying a tablet on the table between them. "They used to fall in line the moment Azaar's name came up. Now they just... wait. And the Model Town house stopped sending its tribute of information. No refusal. No message. Just silence."

"And the sigil in Baghbanpura?"

"Someone painted Azaar's old mark over yours on the warehouse wall. Then scratched it out again before finishing." Jasmine's mouth tightened. "Like they couldn't decide whose city this is either."

Muqsit turned that over. "It's not an army."

"No," Jasmine agreed. "It's smaller than that. And it's worse. It's doubt."

Before he could answer, the intercom chimed, low and formal, the way it never had for Azaar's enemies and rarely did for anyone at all.

"There's someone at the gate," the guard said, voice careful. "She says her name is Almas. She says you'll want to see her before you decide not to."

Jasmine went very still. "Let her up."

"You know her," Muqsit said. Not a question.

"I know of her," Jasmine said. "Azaar never touched her territory. Not once, not even at the height of his power. I always assumed that was his choice. I'm starting to think it was hers."

Almas arrived without escort, without weapons visible, wrapped in a shawl the color of old rust. She was small, unhurried, and the room seemed to organize itself around her the moment she stepped into it, the way a held breath organizes a chest.

She looked at Muqsit for a long moment before she spoke. "So. The half-blood who ended a grandfather-line and a lord in the same season." Her eyes, when they caught the light, held no color Muqsit could name. "I did not come to bow, boy. My house was old when Jasmine's grandfather was young, and I have outlasted three empires that thought themselves permanent. I came to see if there is anything here worth measuring."

"And is there?" Muqsit asked.

Almas's smile did not reach anywhere near warmth. "I haven't decided if you're a king, or a mistake wearing a king's face." She turned toward the door, unhurried as she'd come.

"Convince me quickly. Others are already deciding without waiting for my opinion, and their answer will be simpler than mine. It will involve fire."

She left the way she'd arrived, without sound, without permission asked or given.

Jasmine exhaled slowly once the elevator doors closed three floors below.

"That," she said, "was Almas being polite."

*Chapter 24*

THE MILL ON MULTAN ROAD

Word of Almas's visit moved through Lahore's old blood faster than Muqsit could have managed it himself, and it moved wrong, the way rumors always do. By the time it reached the far edge of the city, "she did not bow" had become "she came to judge him and found him wanting."

In a basement beneath a shuttered textile mill on Multan Road, three of Azaar's former lieutenants heard that version and believed it, because it was the version they needed.

"A half-human sits on Azaar's throne," the eldest of them hissed, "and now even Almas won't kneel to him. This is our chance, before someone stronger takes it instead of us."

"And if we're wrong about her?" another asked.

"Then we will already have ended him before anyone else can," the eldest said. "A dead exception is no exception at all."

They moved before dawn.

Muqsit felt it before Jasmine's phone buzzed, a pull in the dark like a held breath somewhere across the city, the same instinct that had once made him lunge for a blade in Azaar's siege.

"Something's wrong," he said, already moving for the door.

By the time he reached the mill, the three lieutenants had already killed the two guards Jasmine had posted there and set fire to the loading dock, more theater than tactic, a message written in flame for all of Lahore to read: the empire cannot even hold its own house.

Muqsit walked into the smoke without hesitation. "You want a throne," he said, voice carrying over the crackle of burning wood, "come take it from my hands instead of setting fires like frightened children."

They came at him together, fast and coordinated in the way only centuries of shared service could make them. Muqsit fought differently now than he had against Azaar; less desperation, more certainty, every block placed like he already knew the strike before it landed. He broke the eldest one's wrist with a single turn, drove another into a support beam hard enough to bring down half the roof, and when the third tried to flee into the dark, Jasmine was already waiting there, crimson eyes glowing, blade drawn.

"Kneel," Muqsit said to the two who remained, "or join the third."

They knelt.

From the shadows at the mill's broken doorway, a small figure in a rust-colored shawl watched the entire fight without announcing herself, arms folded, expression unreadable.

"You could have let them burn the city looking for a reason to condemn you," Almas said afterward, stepping into the thinning smoke as though she'd always been standing there. "You didn't."

"I don't need a reason to be cruel," Muqsit said, breathing hard, blood on his knuckles that wasn't his own. "I have better uses for the city than burning it."

Almas studied the two kneeling lieutenants, then him, the way a jeweler studies a stone before deciding whether to cut it or set it whole. "Discipline. Mercy, even, to the ones

who knelt. That is not what Azaar's line was known for. That is not what the grandfather taught either."

"So what does that make me?" Muqsit asked.

"Something Lahore's old blood has never had to make room for," Almas said. "That is either the most dangerous thing I have seen in three centuries, or the most useful. I still haven't decided which."



THE WEIGHT OF THE CROWN

Almas returned to the penthouse at dusk the following day, this time asking to be announced, which Jasmine took as its own kind of verdict.

"My house will not move against you," she said, without preamble. "Not because I fear you, half-blood, but because I've watched three centuries of Lahore's old blood tear itself apart chasing thrones weaker men couldn't hold, and you are, at the very least, not weak." She settled into a chair no one had offered her. "That buys you my patience. It does not buy you my loyalty. Those are different currencies, and I spend them differently."

"What would it take?" Jasmine asked. "The loyalty."

"Time," Almas said simply. "And the discipline he showed at the mill, repeated, again and again, until it stops looking like restraint and starts looking like character. Lahore's old families are patient. We have outlived kinder rulers than you by simply waiting for them to become someone worse." Her eyes found Muqsit's, and for once there was no mockery in them. "Don't become someone worse."

"And the others?" Muqsit asked. "The ones who don't share your patience."

"There are houses in Multan, in Peshawar, along the old trade roads, who answered to Azaar's name out of habit rather than loyalty," Almas said. "Some will test you the way those three fools did, badly, out of impatience. A few will be smarter about it. None of them are an army, Muqsit. They are simply blood that hasn't decided yet whether kneeling to you costs more than standing against you." She rose, gathering her shawl.

"That decision will take years, not seasons. I suggest you survive long enough to let it."

She left without further ceremony, and this time Jasmine did not call it politeness.

Later, on the rooftop where they'd watched the dawn together weeks before, Jasmine found Muqsit still turning Almas's words over.

"You're not afraid of her," she said. It wasn't a question.

"I stopped being afraid of thrones the night I took one from a man who thought he was unkillable," Muqsit said. "Whatever Lahore's old blood decides, we'll meet it the way we met him. Together."

Jasmine leaned into him, the city's lights spreading gold and crimson beneath them, older than either of them and, for the first time in centuries, alive with something closer to hope than dread.

"Then let them test you," she murmured. "One house at a time, for as many years as it takes. Lahore has survived worse than a slow verdict."

Far below, the empire settled into an uneasy quiet, not because its true test had passed, but because it had only just begun; not a council or a court sending judgment from some distant city, but the old blood of Lahore itself, deciding, house by house, year by year, whether the crown on a half-human's head was a warning or a beginning.



Crimson Empire: The Rise of Muqsit — Sheharzad Salabuddin

Crimson Empire

**THE SECOND VERSION IS
COMING SOON**